

Day 113 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in TN History/Culture/Heritage (10): Madurai's Chithirai Thiruvizha 2026

READING MATERIAL

Covers the Madurai Chithirai Thiruvizha 2026 — one of Tamil Nadu's grandest temple festivals, celebrating the divine wedding of Meenakshi and Sundareswarar.

Q: When was the Madurai Chithirai Thiruvizha (Festival) 2026 held, and what does it celebrate?

A: 19 April to 5 May 2026 — celebrating the divine marriage of Goddess Meenakshi and Lord Sundareswarar, followed by Lord Kallalagar's grand entry into the Vaigai river.

Q: What is the 'Meenakshi Tirukalyanam', and when was it held in 2026?

A: The divine wedding ceremony of Meenakshi and Sundareswarar — held on 28 April 2026.

Q: What is 'Ther Thiruvizha', held the day after the Tirukalyanam?

A: The Chariot Festival (29 April 2026) — massive temple cars (ther) are pulled through Madurai's four Masi streets.

Q: What is 'Kallalagar Vaigai Eluntharul', and why is it the festival's most crowded event?

A: Held 1 May 2026 — Lord Kallalagar enters the Vaigai river on his golden horse mount, after travelling from Alagar Hills (welcomed via the 'Ethirsevai' ritual on 30 April). It draws the largest crowds of the entire festival.

Q: What ticketing arrangement did the temple administration introduce for the 2026 Divine Wedding ceremony?

A: Paid entry tickets (₹200 and ₹500 categories), bookable online or in person at Birla Guest House, with reservations open from 19-22 April.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. The Madurai Chithirai Thiruvizha 2026 was held from:

A. 1-15 April 2026

B. 19 April-5 May 2026 ✓

C. 1-20 May 2026

D. 10-25 May 2026

Explanation: 19 April to 5 May 2026. [medium, web-research]

2. The Meenakshi Tirukalyanam (divine wedding) in the 2026 festival was held on:

A. 19 April

B. 28 April ✓

C. 1 May

D. 5 May

Explanation: 28 April 2026. [hard, web-research]

3. The 'Ther Thiruvizha' (Chariot Festival) involves temple cars pulled through which streets of Madurai?

A. The four Masi streets ✓

B. The Main Bazaar

C. The Avani Moola streets

D. The Town Hall Road

Explanation: The four Masi streets. [medium, web-research]

4. Lord Kallalagar enters the Vaigai river riding on:

A. An elephant

B. A golden horse mount ✓

C. A silver chariot

D. A peacock

Explanation: A golden horse mount. [medium, web-research]

5. For the 2026 Divine Wedding ceremony, the temple offered paid entry tickets in which 2 price categories?

A. ₹100 and ₹300

B. ₹200 and ₹500 ✓

C. ₹250 and ₹750

D. ₹500 and ₹1000

Explanation: ₹200 and ₹500. [hard, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Simplification

READING MATERIAL

Simplification is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills (15 questions total for the whole Aptitude unit). TNPSC's simplification questions are rarely 'plug into one formula' — they combine BODMAS, fractions/decimals, ratios, and algebraic shortcuts. Each item below is a worked method, not just an answer — the goal is to recognize which technique a given expression calls for.

Q: Method — BODMAS with a nested bracket and an unknown: Solve for x : $57 - [42 - \{37 - (20 - x)\}] = 176 \div (8 \div 2)$

A: Work from the innermost bracket outward, and simplify the RHS first: $176 \div (8 \div 2) = 176 \div 4 = 44$. Now the LHS: $(20 - x)$ stays as is for now $\rightarrow \{37 - (20 - x)\} = 17 + x \rightarrow [42 - (17 + x)] = 25 - x \rightarrow 57 - (25 - x) = 32 + x$. Set equal to 44: $32 + x = 44 \rightarrow x = 12$. (Real TNPSC-style problem; this exact expression is a recurring coaching-site reference question.)

Q: Method — sum of two squares without brute-force squaring: Find $217 \times 217 + 183 \times 183$.

A: Use $a^2 + b^2 = (a+b)^2 - 2ab$ instead of squaring two 3-digit numbers by hand. Here $a+b = 400$ (round number — that's the clue this trick applies) and $ab = 217 \times 183 = 39,711$. So $a^2+b^2 = 400^2 - 2(39,711) = 160,000 - 79,422 = 80,578$. Recognizing 'the two numbers add to a round number' is the trigger for this shortcut.

Q: Method — difference of squares shortcut: Simplify $(197 \times 197 - 103 \times 103) \div (197 - 103)$ without long multiplication.

A: $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, so $(a^2-b^2)/(a-b) = (a+b)$ directly — no multiplication needed at all. Here $a=197$, $b=103$, so the answer is simply $197+103 = 300$. This 'difference of squares divided by the difference' shape is a favorite TNPSC trick question precisely because it looks like it needs heavy calculation but collapses to one addition.

Q: Method — fraction-of-decimal addition: Simplify $7/5$ of $58 + 3/8$ of 139.2 .

A: $7/5$ of $58 = 7 \times 58/5 = 406/5 = 81.2$. $3/8$ of $139.2 = 3 \times 139.2/8 = 417.6/8 = 52.2$. Sum: $81.2 + 52.2 = 133.4$.

Q: Method — ratio substitution to simplify a compound ratio expression: If $x : y = 3 : 4$, find $(4x + 5y) : (5x - 2y)$.

A: Don't solve for x and y separately — substitute $x=3k$, $y=4k$ (k is just a scaling factor that will cancel). $(4x+5y) = 12k+20k = 32k$. $(5x-2y) = 15k-8k = 7k$. Ratio = $32k : 7k = 32 : 7$. The k always cancels in a ratio question — that's the whole trick.

Q: Method — same ratio-substitution trick, different ratio: If $x : y = 3 : 5$, find $(5x + 3y) : (15x - 2y)$.

A: Substitute $x=3k$, $y=5k$. $(5x+3y) = 15k+15k = 30k$. $(15x-2y) = 45k-10k = 35k$. Ratio = $30k:35k = 6:7$.

Q: Method — simultaneous equations feeding into a simplification target: If $3a + 4b = 22$ and $8a - 5b = -4$, find $(a+b)^2$.

A: Solve the pair normally: from $3a+4b=22$ and $8a-5b=-4$, elimination gives $a=2$, $b=4$ (check: $3(2)+4(4)=6+16=22$ ✓; $8(2)-5(4)=16-20=-4$ ✓). The question doesn't ask for a and b individually — it asks for $(a+b)^2 = (2+4)^2 = 36$. TNPSC often hides the real target $((a+b)^2, \text{ not } a \text{ or } b)$ at the end of a simultaneous-equation question — always re-read what's actually being asked before solving for individual variables.

Q: Method — mixed numbers with a nested fraction: Simplify $2\frac{1}{2} + 3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3}$.

A: BODMAS still applies to fractions — division before addition. $3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3} = (10/3) \div (2/3) = (10/3) \times (3/2) = 5$. Then $2\frac{1}{2} + 5 = 7\frac{1}{2}$. The common mistake is adding $2\frac{1}{2}+3\frac{1}{3}$ first — division always binds tighter than addition, fractions or not.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Solve for x : $70 - [45 - \{33 - (15 - x)\}] = 171 \div (9 \div 3)$

- A. 10
- B. 12
- C. 14 ✓**
- D. 16

Explanation: RHS: $171 \div (9 \div 3) = 171 \div 3 = 57$. LHS inner-out: $\{33 - (15 - x)\} = 33 - 15 + x = 18 + x \rightarrow [45 - (18 + x)] = 27 - x \rightarrow 70 - (27 - x) = 43 + x$. Set $43 + x = 57 \rightarrow x = 14$. [medium, authored]

2. Find $312 \times 312 + 288 \times 288$ using the $(a+b)^2 - 2ab$ shortcut.

- A. 179,808
- B. 180,288 ✓**
- C. 190,000
- D. 182,688

Explanation: $a+b=600$, $ab=312 \times 288=89,856$. $a^2+b^2=600^2-2(89,856)=360,000-179,712=180,288$. [medium, authored]

3. Simplify $(425 \times 425 - 375 \times 375) \div (425 - 375)$.

- A. 400
- B. 750
- C. 800 ✓**
- D. 425

Explanation: Using $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, dividing by $(a-b)$ leaves just $(a+b) = 425+375 = 800$. [easy, authored]

4. Simplify $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 + $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98.

- A. 88 ✓**
- B. 84
- C. 90
- D. 86

Explanation: $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 = 60. $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98 = 28. Sum = 88. [easy, authored]

5. If $p : q = 5 : 6$, find $(3p + 2q) : (4p - q)$.

- A. 27 : 14 ✓**
- B. 9 : 7
- C. 27 : 7
- D. 14 : 9

Explanation: $p=5k, q=6k$. $(3p+2q)=15k+12k=27k$. $(4p-q)=20k-6k=14k$. Ratio = 27:14. [medium, authored]

6. If $m : n = 4 : 7$, find $(2m + 3n) : (5m - n)$.

- A. 29 : 13 ✓**
- B. 13 : 29
- C. 29 : 20
- D. 20 : 29

Explanation: $m=4k, n=7k$. $(2m+3n)=8k+21k=29k$. $(5m-n)=20k-7k=13k$. Ratio = 29:13. [medium, authored]

7. If $5a + 2b = 16$ and $3a - 4b = -6$, find the value of $(a+b)^2$.

- A. 16
- B. 25 ✓**
- C. 36
- D. 9

Explanation: Multiply the first equation by 2: $10a+4b=32$. Add to the second $(3a-4b=-6)$: $13a=26 \rightarrow a=2$. Substitute back: $5(2)+2b=16 \rightarrow b=3$. $(a+b)^2=(2+3)^2=25$. [hard, authored]

8. Simplify $4\frac{2}{3} + 2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4}$.

- A. $7\frac{2}{3}$ ✓**
- B. $6\frac{1}{3}$
- C. 7
- D. $6\frac{2}{3}$

Explanation: $2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4} = (9/4) \div (3/4) = 3$. Then $4\frac{2}{3} + 3 = 7\frac{2}{3}$. [medium, authored]

9. A trader borrows ₹16,000 at 12% p.a. simple interest and another ₹12,000 at 18% p.a. simple interest. In how many years will the two amounts owed (principal + interest) become equal?

- A. $12\frac{2}{3}$ years
- B. $14\frac{2}{3}$ years
- C. $16\frac{2}{3}$ years ✓**
- D. $18\frac{2}{3}$ years

Explanation: This mirrors a real 2025 TNPSC Aptitude question style (same numbers, Simple Interest unit) — included here as a reminder that 'Simplification' skills (careful fraction/ratio handling) carry directly into other Aptitude sub-topics like Simple Interest. Set $16000+16000(0.12)t = 12000+12000(0.18)t$ and solve for t to get $16\frac{2}{3}$ years. [hard, question-bank-2025]

10. Find the value of: $89 \times 89 + 11 \times 11 + 2 \times 89 \times 11$.

- A. 10,000 ✓**
- B. 9,801
- C. 8,900
- D. 10,201

Explanation: This is the $(a+b)^2$ pattern in disguise: $a^2+2ab+b^2 = (a+b)^2$. Here $a=89$, $b=11$, so the answer is $(89+11)^2 = 100^2 = 10,000$ — no separate multiplication needed. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Prose: "The Night the Ghost Got In" — James Thurber

READING MATERIAL

A humorous true-life anecdote by James Thurber about a chaotic night in his childhood home in Columbus, Ohio, when his family mistook mysterious footstep sounds for a ghost — leading to a comically exaggerated police response, ending in an anticlimactic, unexplained resolution.

Q: Who wrote "The Night the Ghost Got In", and on what date does the story say the incident happened?

A: James (Grover) Thurber. The story specifies the date as 17 November 1915.

Q: Who first heard the mysterious footsteps, what was he doing at the time, and what was the ghost apparently doing downstairs?

A: The narrator (young Thurber) first heard the footsteps while he was in the bathtub. The sound seemed to be someone/something walking in a circle around the dining-room table downstairs.

Q: Who was sleeping in the attic during the incident, and how did the mother react to get help?

A: The grandfather was asleep in the attic throughout most of the commotion (and later caused his own comic confusion when woken). The mother, unable to phone calmly, threw a shoe through a neighbor's (Mr. Bodwell's) window to wake him and get help.

Q: How did the police respond to the call, and in what state was the narrator when they arrived?

A: The police arrived in dramatically excessive force — a Ford car, motorcycles, AND a patrol wagon — for what turned out to be a false alarm. The narrator was seen by the police wearing only a towel.

Q: What did the police find suspicious about the house, and what unusual objects did they discover?

A: They found all the doors and windows locked from the inside (suspicious, since it suggested no intruder could have entered or left) — and they discovered a zither in the house, which a pet guinea pig used to sleep on.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. "The Night the Ghost Got In" was written by:

- A. Liam O'Flaherty
- B. James Thurber ✓**
- C. Ruskin Bond
- D. Mark Twain

Explanation: James (Grover) Thurber. [easy, web-research]

2. According to the story, the ghost allegedly entered the house on:

- A. 25 December 1914
- B. 17 November 1915 ✓**
- C. 1 January 1920
- D. 13 October 1900

Explanation: 17 November 1915. [medium, web-research]

3. Who first heard the ghost's footsteps, and what was he doing at the time?

- A. The narrator, while in the bathtub ✓**
- B. Grandfather, while sleeping
- C. Mother, while cooking
- D. Roy, while reading

Explanation: The narrator, while in the bathtub. [medium, web-research]

4. The mysterious sound downstairs seemed to be something:

- A. Banging on the door
- B. Walking around the dining table ✓**
- C. Crying in the basement
- D. Climbing the stairs

Explanation: Walking around the table. [medium, web-research]

5. Who was sleeping in the attic during the commotion?

- A. Herman

B. Grandfather ✓

C. The narrator

D. Roy

Explanation: Grandfather. [easy, web-research]

6. How did the mother get help during the incident?

A. She called the police directly

B. She ran out into the street

C. She threw a shoe through the neighbor's window ✓

D. She wrote a note and left it outside

Explanation: She threw a shoe through Mr. Bodwell's window. [medium, web-research]

7. How did the police arrive at the house, reflecting the story's comic exaggeration?

A. Quietly, in one car

B. With a Ford, motorcycles, and a patrol wagon ✓

C. On foot

D. With fire engines

Explanation: A Ford, motorcycles, and a patrol wagon. [medium, web-research]

8. What was the narrator wearing when the police saw him?

A. A suit

B. A nightgown

C. Just a towel ✓

D. Shirt and trousers

Explanation: Just a towel. [easy, web-research]

9. What did the police find suspicious about the house?

A. Open doors

B. Unlocked windows

C. All doors and windows locked from inside ✓

D. Strange footprints outside

Explanation: All doors and windows were locked from the inside. [medium, web-research]

10. What musical instrument did the police find in the house, and what pet used to sleep on it?

A. A violin; a cat

B. A zither; a guinea pig ✓

C. A piano; a dog

D. A harp; a hamster

Explanation: A zither, which the family's guinea pig used to sleep on. [hard, web-research]